

Chapter 10: Alcohol and Drug Impact on the Driving Ability

Any drug may affect a person's ability to drive. Millions of people take over the counter and prescription medications, illegal drugs, or drink alcohol and do not realize they may affect the mental and physical (psychomotor) skills necessary to operate a vehicle and react to external events while driving a vehicle.

Each individual is different. The driving skills of persons taking the same drug may be affected differently. A driver's body weight, emotional state, amount of drug taken, and when the drug was taken will influence the driver's ability to assess an emergency situation or judge speed and distance. Safe driving always requires an observant eye, a steady hand, and a clear head.

When a person drinks alcohol or uses drugs, one of the first effects is they lose their judgement and their sight is impaired, causing slower reactions to sounds and the inability to judge another vehicle's speed. A person's ability to reason can all but disappear. Good judgment may be as simple as saying no to a friend who wants to race their car. However, if a person has been drinking alcohol or they are under the influence of drugs, their judgment may turn into, "Sure, take my car."

Taking more than one drug at the same time is even more dangerous since drugs may have a different overall cumulative effect, especially when alcohol is involved. Besides escalating the overall effects of the other drugs, alcohol can also mask the effects of those drugs, increasing a person's risk of poor decision making and/or slowing responsive reactions to situations. You should always check with a doctor or pharmacist before taking more than one type of drug or mixing drugs, especially tranquilizers or sedatives.

Table 25: Alcohol and Other Types of Drugs

Type	Description
Marijuana	Research shows even typical social doses of marijuana can affect concentration, judgment, and sensory and perceptual skills needed for careful driving. People who are under marijuana influence have impaired sensory and perceptual abilities.
Stimulants	Heavy amphetamine use may keep drivers awake and active for long periods of time. It also makes them less coordinated, edgy, and more likely to be involved in a car crash. Research shows typical social amounts of cocaine can produce lapses in attention and concentration. While caffeine can help drowsy drivers stay alert, it can't make a drunk driver sober. Studies show ordinary amounts of caffeine don't improve a drunk driver's ability to operate a vehicle.
Tranquilizers / Sedative-Hypnotics	Tranquilizers/Sedative-hypnotic drugs, including barbiturates, are powerful depressants, which calm people down or help them sleep. Tired or over-sedated drivers are not good drivers.
Over-the-counter drugs	Many over-the-counter drugs cause drowsiness in some people, which can affect their driving. Read the labels and be careful with antihistamines, other cold preparations, or any medicine that relaxes or promotes sleep.
Any drug	Any drug might affect your ability as a driver. If you take more than one drug or if you mix drugs, especially tranquilizers or other sedative-hypnotics with alcohol, you could be asking for trouble on the road and off. If you have doubts about a drug or drug mix, check with a doctor or pharmacist.
Alcohol	Each year alcohol, a depressant drug affecting coordination, judgment, perception, and emotional state, is responsible for a significant number of highway deaths. Alcohol increases the depressant effects of tranquilizers and barbiturates. Mixing these drugs, on or off the road, can be hazardous.

The Number One Killer is Alcohol

Driving While Intoxicated (DWI) is a problem affecting all Texans. According to the Calendar Year 2018 *Texas Motor Vehicle Traffic Crash Facts* (TxDOT), 940 persons were killed in a motor vehicle traffic crash with a driver under the influence of alcohol. Alcohol related crashes represent 26% of the total number of persons killed in motor vehicle traffic crashes.

The Centers for Disease Control (CDC) states that the leading cause of death for U.S. teens is accidental and most of those are motor vehicle crashes. According to the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration (NHTSA), 3,255 teen (age 15 to 19) drivers were involved in fatal crashes in 2017 and nearly 25% of those had been drinking.

In 2018, TxDOT reports that nearly 7% of all fatal crashes involved a driver under the age of 21 who was under the influence of alcohol. Texas law does not allow any amount of blood alcohol concentration (BAC) for minors.

To make Texas safer, the Texas legislature enacted laws to deter people from drinking and driving by penalizing those who choose to drink and drive. In Texas, a person, age 21 and over, is considered legally intoxicated if the person has a BAC of 0.08 or more. Driving While Intoxicated (DWI) and Driving Under the Influence (DUI) arrests can be a humiliating experience and are costly. Some fines range as high as \$10,000 not including the cost of a bail bondsman, attorney, or other court-required expenses. Is it worth the risk?